EXCLUSIVE INTERVIEW | GEN. ANIL CHAUHAN

"OPERATION SINDOOR WAS OUR FIRST NETWORK CENTRIC WAR"

India's military stands at a moment of profound transition. The rules of warfare are being rewritten in real time—by drones and artificial intelligence, cyber conflict and electronic warfare, contested borders and rapidly shifting geopolitical fault lines. For the man at the centre of that transformation, *Chief of Defence Staff* GENERAL ANIL CHAUHAN, the challenge has been not just preparing for the next war, but redesigning India's military for a new era of conflict. In a wide-ranging interview with *India Today Group Editorial Director* RAJ CHENGAPPA and *Deputy Editor* PRADIP R. SAGAR, just days before demitting office after a four-year stint, Gen. Chauhan reflects on the defining challenges of his tenure and outlines how India's armed forces are preparing for this radically changing battlespace—from Operation Sindoor and the China challenge to theatre commands, drones, cyber warfare and AI. Excerpts:

Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**

Q. How did Operation Sindoor change India's thinking in terms of deterrence and military response?

Operation Sindoor was fundamentally different from the kind of operations or warfare we had witnessed earlier. In many ways, it represented our first truly multi-domain operation. All three services worked together in an integrated manner, but beyond that, we also brought in elements of cyberspace and information warfare as part of the operational framework. This level of coordination was not achieved overnight. It was the result of sustained efforts over the past three to four years towards greater jointness and integration among the services. During the operation, that integration played out exceptionally well. At several levels, the coordination and understanding between the services were remarkable. For me, this operation was a strong reaffirmation that the path we have taken towards integration and jointness is the correct one.